The Experiences of Somali Meat Packers: The Case of Willmar, Minnesota

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ABSTRACT

Thousands of Somali refugees have settled in the United States, specifically in Minnesota, since Somalia's civil war erupted in 1991. Many migrated to different rural and smaller cities for the purpose of finding sustainable jobs. Meat processing plants in the rural areas provided jobs, attracted large numbers of Somalis in the past decade. Meatpacking is one of the most dangerous jobs in America because of its physical demands , swift pace of the working conditions. Much like other immigrants before them, Somalis are facing challenges in these meat packing jobs. By conducting interviews with Somali meatpackers and Somali community leaders in Willmar, this study investigated the experiences of Somalis in the meat processing plants and communities, particularly in Willmar. The findings show that Somali meat packers face health and safety issues, as well as cultural and religious challenges.

LITERATURE REVIEW

- Meatpacking workers are the specialists who handle all kinds of meat products every day.
- They mainly deal with poultry, beef and pork, and they use electric knives to cut heavy meat in fast moving lines.
- "The meat plants run as assembly lines, with one person making the same cut over and over as the animals move down the line" (McKinney 2006).
- The meatpacking industry is largely based on the upper Midwestern States in the United States.
- Fast moving lines can slaughter and process more than 400 head of livestock per hour and these kinds of work conditions require workers to stand longer in cold, slippery floors, and use electric knives.
- A report "The Speed is Killing You" showed incident rates, non-fatal occupational injuries 2007 and injury rates in all U.S. manufacturing plants was 5.60%, Poultry plants 6.10%, and meatpacking plants 12.10%.
- Notably, 62% of meatpackers said they have been injured in the past year and the injury continues to increase each year.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

- What is the experience of Somali meatpacking workers in Willmar, Minnesota?
- Although this was the main research question, the participants were asked other open ended questions.

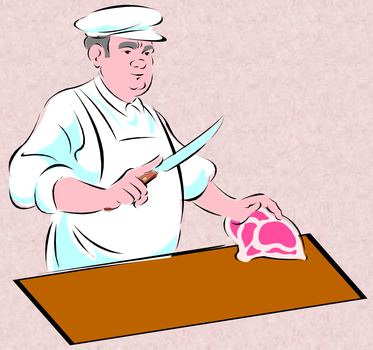
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METHODS

- This is a qualitative study where interviews were conducted with Somali meatpackers and community leaders in Willmar, MN.
- A total of eight interviews were conducted with Somali workers in Willmar who have been working at the meatpacking plants for minimum of six months.
- Local organizations like the Somali Women 's Center and La Gran America, trilingual newspaper of Willmar were contacted in order to recruit participants. The Interviews were planned in the form of semi-structured and open-ended questions to both Somali meatpackers and community leaders.
- Somali meat workers were asked three questions:
  1) How did you find this job?
  2) Can you describe what you do?
  3) Can you describe the type of training you had when you started your job?
- Somali community leaders were asked three questions:
  1) Can you describe the Somali population in Willmar?
  2) What are the main issues that the Somali population faces in Willmar?
  3) What resources are available for the Somalis to integrate in the community?
- Three Somali meatpacking workers were asked to participate in one on one interview at the Somali Women Center, and five were interviewed informally at local grocery stories and coffee shops.
- Three Somali Community leaders were interviewed one on one and one was informally interviewed.



RESULTS

- Three out of the eight participant workers had minor injuries within the past several months.
- Health insurance costs $500 out of each pay check, which is considered a high insurance premium.
- Due to expensive insurance, three workers did not have insurance.
- Participant workers learned about the job openings at Jennie-O from friends and were recruited by friends.
- Participant workers indicated that they have to take extra unpaid 30 minutes every day to get ready for work and put on uniforms. One participant worker said, " I have to be at Jennie-O at 3:30pm or before even though my regular shift starts at 4:00pm."
- Time for prayers and religious practices was not given.
- Participant workers were required to take five minutes. unpaid
- Participants expressed that they have no enjoyment at all in their work, and said they would have liked to quit if they had other work options.
- All workers indicated that they stand during their eight hour shift and the breaks they receive are not enough rest time for them.
- Other challenges that Somali meatpacking workers and the Somali community face in Willmar include: lack of adequate housing, lack of community resources and agencies to help the workers and community in general, racism, and lack of transportation.

LIMITATIONS AND CHALLENGES

- Significant numbers of Somalis work at Jennie-O meat plants in Willmar. However, it was hard to contact many workers due to lack of community resources and lack of experience or trust of Somali workers to participate in research interviews.
- There are less community centers and places that can be contacted to get information about the Somali population in Willmar. The Somali Woman's' Center and LA Gran America were the only two organizations available to contact. These two organizations did not prove to be an adequate base to contact potential participants to be part of this research.
- Also, cultural sensitivity was another difficulty encountered during this research.
- It was hard to convince workers to participate in this research because many of the Somali workers have not been research participants.
- After interviews and participants' points of views, it was obvious that the Somalis working at Jennie-O were not satisfied with their jobs due to poor work conditions.
- The Somali community in Willmar was not stable or integrated in the greater community in Willmar.
- Somalis do not stay long in Willmar if they do not find jobs at the Jennie-O factory.